

The Weekly Digest

Issue Date: 2026-04-25

THE WORLD THIS WEEK

Politics

Donald Trump extended America's ceasefire with Iran at Pakistan's request, but talks faced delays, and both sides continued to impede shipping in the Strait of Hormuz. In Lebanon, Trump brokered a ten-day truce, though Israel insisted on maintaining troops in the south, and Hizbullah accused Israel of breaches. Taiwan's president cancelled an Eswatini visit due to China's pressure on overflight rights. Domestically, Pentagon feuds continued with the sacking of the Navy Secretary, Democrats gained an electoral boost from Virginia's new congressional map, but two Democrats resigned amid scandal. The Justice Department charged the Southern Poverty Law Centre with financial fraud, and the Labor

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Secretary resigned over leadership complaints. In Europe, the defeat of Viktor Orban in Hungary resolved a stalemate on the EU's ?90bn loan to Ukraine, and the EU Court ordered Hungary to lift its ban on gay media for minors. Bulgaria's Eurosceptic Progressive Bulgaria coalition won elections, and Romania faced a government crisis over austerity measures. Britain's Prime Minister, Sir Keir Starmer, faced controversy over Peter Mandelson's appointment as ambassador to America, while the chief rabbi warned of rising antisemitic violence. Japan loosened weapon export restrictions, angering China, which also protested Japanese involvement in US-Philippine military exercises. El Salvador began a mass trial of 486 MS-13 gang members, and Venezuela's opposition leader, María Corina Machado, urged US pressure for elections.

Business

Tim Cook announced he would step down as Apple CEO after 15 years, during which Apple's share price surged

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by nearly 2,000% to a \$4trn valuation, with John Ternus taking over in September. Kevin Warsh's nomination for Federal Reserve chairman faced Senate scrutiny, amid Donald Trump's perceived attempts to influence interest-rate decisions. United Airlines, Lufthansa, and TUI cut profit forecasts and flights due to rising jet fuel prices from the Iran war and reduced travel demand near the conflict zone. Britain's annual inflation rate jumped to 3.3% due to higher motor fuel costs, leading markets to anticipate a Bank of England interest rate hike. America's defence industry, including Northrop Grumman, RTX, and Boeing, reported strong earnings amid increased Pentagon spending for the Iran conflict. Tesla's Q1 net profit rose 17% from a weak prior year, with plans for increased capital expenditure on AI, robotics, and self-driving cars. Share prices of psychedelic drug developers surged after Donald Trump issued an order to accelerate their approval for mental illness treatment. America's customs agency began processing refunds for Trump's "illegal" tariffs,

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amounting to \$166bn. The Swiss government demanded UBS increase its capital by \$20bn, citing "too big to fail" concerns. Meta was revealed to be tracking employee keyboard strokes and mouse movements to train its AI models, raising concerns about job cuts.

The weekly cartoon

No significant coverage this issue.

LEADERS

America is vulnerable to electoral vandalism

America's democracy faces alarming risks despite Democrats' strong midterm election prospects, as Donald Trump's repeated meddling and false claims of a stolen 2020 election have eroded public trust. While an outright theft of the midterms is unlikely due to the decentralized

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electoral system, Trump's attempts to weaponize courts, federalize election administration, and potentially deploy ICE agents to polling stations aim to sow distrust and provide grounds for post-electoral mischief. The damage is more likely to be "vandalism" that further polarizes the nation and entrenches dangerous ideas, making Americans lose faith in each other and their institutions, which could be exploited by future strongmen.

Tim Cook wrote a winning recipe for Apple

Tim Cook's 15-year tenure as Apple CEO has been a remarkable success, growing the company's market value eleven-fold by continuously improving the iPhone and embracing globalization, particularly China, as a manufacturing and sales hub. His successor, John Ternus, now faces the challenge of updating this winning formula for the age of artificial intelligence and geopolitical fracture. While Apple has lagged in developing AI services, its strategy of continuous hardware improvement and leveraging its global supply

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chains has continued to pay off, and the hope is that these foundational elements, bolstered by new AI applications, will ensure its enduring success.

How to bolster the arsenal of democracy

Global rearmament and ongoing conflicts in Ukraine and Iran underscore the urgent need for Western countries to modernize their defense industries, focusing on increased manufacturing capacity, balancing high-end with cheaper weapons, and prioritizing software-driven systems. America's "neo-primers" like Palantir, SpaceX, and Anduril are leading this transformation with agile, software-first approaches and modern manufacturing methods, encouraged by the Trump administration's procurement reforms. Europe, however, lags significantly due to a fragmented market and limited investment in new defence-tech, requiring substantial reforms in spending and procurement, and closer collaboration with Ukraine's innovative defence ecosystem, to avoid relying solely on a handful of

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American firms.

The high price of forever wars

Under Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel has abandoned its traditional national-security doctrine of short, decisive wars, instead becoming embroiled in prolonged conflicts across Gaza, Lebanon, Syria, and Iran. These open-ended campaigns, though initially justified, have led to immense civilian casualties, failed to eliminate threats like Hamas and Hizbullah, and severely eroded Israel's international legitimacy. Netanyahu's pursuit of "total victory" has bypassed achievable objectives and diplomatic solutions, leaving Israel over-extended and increasingly reliant on American intervention to pause conflicts, while both political and military leaders avoid a reckoning for their strategic failures.

Pomp and pageantry won't save Britain's alliance with America

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Britain's "special relationship" with America is at its worst point since 1956, strained by Donald Trump's hostile rhetoric, the Iran war, and Britain's post-Brexit geopolitical drift. King Charles III's upcoming visit to Washington is a bid to regain Trump's favor, but widespread distrust exists between leaders and publics, exacerbated by Trump's bullying and Britain's weakened global standing. Britain's military capabilities are exposed, its nuclear deterrent reliant on the US, and its intelligence co-operation questioned, highlighting the urgent need for increased defense spending, closer ties with Europe, and more competent leadership to navigate this complex relationship.

LETTERS

Is the impending food shock caused by the Iran war preventable?

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Save the Children US argues that the impending food shock from the Iran war is preventable, but not solely through diplomacy at the Strait of Hormuz. The organization stresses that the international system consistently fails to act on early warnings of famine, leading to millions facing acute hunger. They advocate for immediate funding of anticipatory measures, such as pre-positioning supplies and protecting livestock, as a more cost-effective and humane alternative to waiting for humanitarian crises to escalate.

A historical precedent

A reader highlights Emiliano Mundrucu's 1832 lawsuit in Boston challenging racial segregation on a boat as a potential precursor to *Plessy v Ferguson*. Mundrucu, a Brazilian national and secessionist leader, sued a captain for denying his family a cabin due to their race, with the case reaching the Massachusetts Supreme Court, suggesting an earlier challenge to racial segregation laws in America.

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Forging ahead with free trade

A reader contends that Britain joining the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) is more significant than its trade deal with India, citing the CPTPP's wider scope and deeper economic integration. The author notes that Britain's inclusion will allow it to help develop new global standards, emphasizing that the world will continue to pursue globalization gains with or without America.

The religious right on the march

A reader warns against underestimating the threat of Christian nationalism in Britain, cautioning that Nigel Farage's libertarianism may not negate the moral authoritarianism of his allies. They argue that under Britain's first-past-the-post system, fringe beliefs can gain power without a majority, urging serious consideration of this transatlantic political trend.

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Music soothes the mind

A reader shares a personal account of how music serves as a daily bridge to connect with her father, who lives with dementia in Brazil. Despite his cognitive decline, playing the keyboard for him via video call elicits emotional engagement and sometimes singing along, preserving their connection and his dignity across physical distance.

Saints preserve us

Multiple readers offer witty insights into Catholic saints. One highlights Saint Nicholas's sociable nature and diverse patronage, including unmarried people and brewers, as an alternative to martyred saints. Another corrects the patron saint of syphilis to St. Fiacre, also noting his connection to gardening. A third attributes a football team's victory to Cardinal Basil Hume's saintly intervention. The final letter humorously compares the speed of passport queues to the flow of visitors viewing

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St. Francis of Assisi's remains, finding little enlightenment in either.

BY INVITATION

Iran's insistence on controlling Hormuz is penny smart, dollar foolish

Ali Amiri argues that Iran's strategic resilience in the face of the US-Iran conflict has been effective, but its continued insistence on controlling the Strait of Hormuz for short-term gain is ultimately self-defeating. He proposes a synchronized, parallel framework for negotiations, where obligations are met simultaneously, emphasizing economic normalization through expanded oil exports and reconnection to global financial systems. Amiri contends that guaranteeing open and secure passage in Hormuz would position Iran as a steward of stability, building trust and attracting regional

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investment, transforming it into an engine of regional development rather than relying on coercion.

AI is the new Oracle of Delphi. That's bad news

Carissa Véliz argues that the widespread use of predictive AI, which acts as a "prediction machine" across various sectors from hiring to justice, raises critical ethical questions that society is failing to address. She highlights concerns about inherent biases in algorithms, the opaque nature of their decision-making, and their tendency to treat individuals as inert objects, effectively creating self-fulfilling prophecies. Véliz emphasizes that these predictions are "speech acts" that implicitly guide behavior, and warns against a future where unchecked predictive AI undermines human agency and a free society, urging urgent debate and regulation.

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BRIEFING

Might Donald Trump try to rig the midterms?

Democrats are gravely concerned that Donald Trump will attempt to interfere with the upcoming November midterm elections, drawing on his efforts to overturn the 2020 presidential election. Fears include executive orders to federalize election administration, the deployment of immigration agents to suppress minority voter turnout, and widespread lawsuits challenging vote counting and certification. While the decentralized nature of the US electoral system and judicial oversight prevented outright subversion in 2020, Trump's rhetoric has significantly eroded public trust in election fairness and emboldened election deniers. Democrats are engaging in extensive war-gaming and legal preparations, anticipating that while outright theft is unlikely, continued "vandalism" to the democratic

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process could further deepen distrust and polarization.

UNITED STATES

Virginia's redistricting may be the nail in Republicans' coffin

The Economist's new statistical forecast indicates a 98% chance of Democrats flipping the House of Representatives in the 2026 midterms, boosted by Virginia's approval of a new congressional district map expected to yield four additional Democratic seats. The model also surprisingly gives Democrats a 48% probability of taking the Senate, despite a historically challenging map, citing strong generic-ballot polling, successful special election results, and President Trump's low approval rating. Key Senate races in states like North Carolina, Ohio, and Alaska show promising Democratic candidates, potentially leading to a

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significant shift in congressional control.

Wealthy New Yorkers grumble as a new tax looms over fortunes

New York City's new Democratic Socialist mayor, Zohran Mamdani, is implementing his campaign promise to tax the wealthy, with Governor Kathy Hochul proposing a "pied-à-terre tax" on second homes in the city valued at \$5m or more. Expected to raise \$500m annually, the tax aims to fund social programs, though some wealthy residents and property developers criticize it as potentially driving capital away. Despite the grumbling, other ambitious and expensive mayoral initiatives, like universal free childcare, are being implemented incrementally, and the city averted a doormen's strike, suggesting wealthy New Yorkers' worst fears have not fully materialized.

Artificial intelligence is creeping into American lawmaking

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Artificial intelligence chatbots are increasingly being utilized by state legislators and their staff across America for research, crafting arguments, and even drafting legislation, particularly in understaffed legislative bodies. Lawmakers, like South Dakota's Kent Roe, find AI a "search engine on steroids" for refining ideas and constitutional stress tests, while others use it to fact-check lobbyists. Although AI models can "hallucinate," especially with case law, human oversight remains, but concerns are growing about the potential for "slop laws" and the erosion of independent critical thought among elected officials.

Donald Trump's bold new deportation machine

Donald Trump's administration has launched an innovative and legally controversial mass deportation campaign, sending illegal immigrants to "third countries"—nations that are not their origin—in exchange for cash or diplomatic concessions. At least 16 countries,

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primarily in Africa and Latin America, have agreed to accept these deportees, even if it means sending them to repressive regimes where they face "refoulement." Critics argue this transactional diplomacy violates international asylum laws and bypasses judicial processes, with the primary aim being to deter immigration and compel uncooperative home countries to accept their own citizens.

Why Congress keeps getting dumber

Senator Thom Tillis of North Carolina stands out as a rare Republican willing to defy President Donald Trump, exemplified by his blocking of a Federal Reserve nominee due to a politically motivated investigation. Lexington argues that Tillis's independent actions, rooted in his pragmatism and commitment to institutional roles, highlight a broader problem in American politics: both parties increasingly punish bipartisanship and compromise, forcing out "wily pragmatists" in favor of ideological purity. This trend, Tillis believes, is making

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Congress less effective and less relevant, failing to build durable majorities in a politically "purple" America.

THE AMERICAS

As the World Cup approaches, North American relations are at a nadir

North American unity is severely strained ahead of the jointly hosted World Cup, largely due to President Donald Trump's aggressive rhetoric and protectionist policies towards Mexico and Canada. Trump's threats against Mexican drug gangs and suggestions of annexing Canada have created deep discord, exacerbated by tariffs and the uncertain future of the USMCA trade deal, which is up for review. Despite deep economic integration and spanning supply chains, the once-aspirational "United As One" slogan for the World Cup now reflects a region grappling with diminished

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trust and fractured political will, pushing Canada and Mexico to explore alternative trade partnerships.

Albertans find it harder than expected to break from Canada. Good

Alberta's "Wexit" independence movement is losing momentum, facing declining public support and significant political and legal hurdles despite earlier surges in popularity. Efforts to gather signatures for a referendum have proven challenging, and the movement is complicated by its awkward relationship with Donald Trump. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney has also addressed some of Alberta's grievances, dampening separatist sentiment. Crucially, Indigenous First Nations are legally challenging the prospect of independence, arguing it would undermine their treaties and potentially stymie the movement entirely.

A botched election adds to Peru's democratic dysfunction

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Peru's recent election was marred by widespread delays and voter frustration, deepening the country's democratic dysfunction and eroding trust in institutions. Keiko Fujimori secured a spot in the presidential run-off, but the second-place candidate remains uncertain, locked in a tight race between a leftist and an ultraconservative, with a full count delayed until mid-May. Allegations of fraud and threats of "insurgency" from the ultraconservative candidate further destabilize the political climate, while renewed tensions with the United States over a fighter jet deal add to the turmoil, leaving the country with a weak mandate and an "explosive combination" of distrust.

ASIA

What do the geopolitical successes of Asim Munir mean for Pakistan?

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Pakistan's Army Chief Asim Munir has emerged as a powerful geopolitical player, successfully mediating an extension of the US-Iran ceasefire and being lauded by Donald Trump. Munir, a wily and ambitious strongman, aims to elevate Pakistan's international standing and leverage its role in Middle Eastern reconstruction, potentially securing investment and pushing for sanctions removal. Despite this diplomatic success, his dominance has deepened Pakistan's domestic problems, including economic struggles, a stifled opposition, and an increasingly militarized hybrid government, raising doubts about whether his efforts will benefit the general population.

Honking is harming India's health and its economy

India's cities suffer from severe noise pollution, primarily due to incessant honking, with average levels in Delhi four times higher than WHO recommendations. This persistent noise is linked to over 60 million Indians

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experiencing hearing loss, increases the risk of heart disease, and is estimated to shave 0.6% off India's GDP annually. Despite these significant health and economic costs, the issue receives little public attention, contrasting sharply with China's state-led efforts to quiet its cities.

An anti-China protest lands Kazakhs in prison

Eleven Kazakh citizens were jailed for five years for inciting racial strife after a peaceful anti-China protest, highlighting Beijing's growing political influence over Central Asian nations. The demonstrators, including Kazakhs from Xinjiang, criticized human rights abuses in the region and demanded the release of a detained citizen, actions that prompted China to pressure Kazakhstan's government for silence. This trial underscores how Central Asian countries, economically reliant on China, often suppress internal dissent to maintain loyalty to Beijing.

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Why Japan is loosening restrictions on exports of lethal arms

Japan is undertaking a historic shift to loosen long-standing restrictions on lethal arms exports, driven by escalating regional tensions with an assertive China and concerns over America's reliability. Prime Minister Takaichi Sanae aims to spur a domestic defense industrial renaissance, boosting production, expanding capacity, and lowering costs to reduce reliance on foreign suppliers. While praised by allies, China denounced the "reckless actions of a new Japanese militarism," as Japan focuses on niche areas like submarines and ships, with challenges remaining in scaling production and adapting to new warfare domains.

What have the Mughals ever done for us?

Narendra Modi's Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) promotes a narrative of India's "1,200 years of slavery" under Muslim empires, particularly the Mughals, largely

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ignoring their profound contributions to Indian culture. Despite the Mughals' influence on language, cuisine, architecture, music, and syncretism, their quincentenary passed unnoted. The article argues that by framing the Mughals as an "eternal, indispensable villain," the BJP strategically leveraged historical grievances, notably the demolition of a mosque at a disputed site, to consolidate its base and rise to power.

CHINA

How Chinese satellites have boosted Iran's war effort

China has indirectly, yet significantly, supported Iran's war effort through the widespread release of images from its rapidly expanding satellite constellations, filling a void left by US firms' restrictions. This proliferation of high-resolution images, provided by Chinese companies

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with close ties to the military, reflects China's advanced Earth-observation capabilities and its willingness to operate beyond Western "shutter control." While offering greater transparency for open-source analysts, it also raises concerns about potential collaboration with Iran and the use of AI to enhance intelligence from these images, demonstrating China's growing influence in space-based intelligence.

Why China's exports will keep on rising

China's exports continue to defy expectations, achieving a record \$1.2trn trade surplus in 2025 and sustained growth in early 2026, despite escalating trade wars and tariffs. This resilience is attributed to a fundamental shift towards higher-value intermediate and capital goods, finding new global markets beyond the US, and a boost from the artificial intelligence boom driving demand for semiconductors. The competitiveness of Chinese goods, underpinned by deflation and a weakened yuan, is also a key factor, although potential trade resistance from

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Europe and the impact of the Iran war pose new challenges.

The world wants Chinese tech. China is determined to keep it

Foreign business and political leaders are now concerned that China is too effective at preventing its world-leading technologies, from electric vehicles to AI-powered robots, from flowing abroad, a reversal from previous worries about too much technology transfer into China. Chaguan argues that a "reverse tech transfer" will inevitably occur as other countries offer market access in exchange for local manufacturing and learn from China's past methods of acquiring foreign tech. Despite China's export controls and leadership paranoia, the ultra-competitive business environment and suppliers' need for profits will likely incentivize the outflow of Chinese innovation.

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MIDDLE EAST & AFRICA

Israel's open-ended wars have eroded its security

Israel has abandoned its traditional national-security doctrine of short, decisive wars under Binyamin Netanyahu, leading to prolonged and devastating conflicts in Gaza, Lebanon, and Iran. These open-ended wars have caused extensive civilian casualties, failed to eliminate threats, and severely eroded Israel's international legitimacy, with US President Donald Trump repeatedly intervening to impose ceasefires. Netanyahu's pursuit of "total victory" has bypassed diplomatic solutions and accountability, leaving Israel militarily over-extended and increasingly dependent on external forces, particularly the US, to manage conflicts.

An extended ceasefire over Iran, but for how long?

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Donald Trump extended America's ceasefire with Iran, but talks remain stalled due to Iran's "fractured" government and its demand for the US to lift its port blockade as a precondition for negotiations. Both sides believe they hold the advantage, making a diplomatic resolution difficult, with Iran suffering from storage capacity limits for its oil and the US facing high petrol prices that could impact the midterms. The mutual blockades have severely disrupted oil markets, raising the risk of renewed conflict if a face-saving compromise is not found, despite both parties' apparent reluctance for further destruction.

Which Iran is America dealing with?

A power vacuum at the top of Iran's leadership following the death of its supreme leader has created a "jungle of power," leading to deep divisions and indecision in negotiations with America. Rival factions, including pragmatic nationalists and hardline Islamists like the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), hold

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conflicting views on critical issues such as the nuclear program, control of Gulf waters, and regional proxies. This internal strife, exacerbated by political assassinations and dispersed command, makes it challenging for any American delegation to identify a unified counterpart, potentially stalling efforts to achieve a truce.

How a Sudanese militia built a military and economic empire

Three years into Sudan's civil war, the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) militia has transformed into a transnational military and economic empire, controlling roughly half the country and extending its influence beyond Sudan's borders. Led by Muhammad Hamdan Dagalo, the RSF has secured arms and fuel flows through a web of alliances and logistics hubs in neighboring countries, including Ethiopia and the Central African Republic. Its military prowess is fueled by deep pockets derived from gold mining and smuggling, and its growing legitimacy

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is evident in the formation of a parallel government, making General Burhan's goal of "eliminating" the RSF seem increasingly remote.

Abiy Ahmed is throttling free expression in Ethiopia

Ethiopian Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, once hailed as a champion of free expression, has drastically suppressed media freedom and dissent ahead of an election in June. His government has jailed rivals, co-opted opposition parties, and targeted independent journalists, with Million Beyene, managing editor of the Addis Standard, recently abducted by masked men. Authorities have revoked media licenses and threatened those critical of the government, treating any criticism as an "information war" and a matter of "national survival," forcing many journalists into exile.

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EUROPE

Can the Germans fight?

Germany is embarking on a historic rearmament effort, with General Carsten Breuer leading the transformation of the Bundeswehr to become "war-ready" and Europe's strongest conventional army by 2035. The new military strategy, emphasizing data primacy, cheap unmanned systems, and deep-precision strikes, will be backed by a massive increase in defense spending, aiming for 3.5% of GDP by 2029. This pivot signals Germany's bold move towards military leadership in Europe, despite challenges in improving notoriously slow procurement processes and recruiting 260,000 troops amid public resistance to potential conscription.

Ukraine's quest for new friends takes it to Turkey and Syria

Driven by American unreliability, Ukraine is

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strategically forging new alliances with Turkey and Syria. President Zelensky's surprise visit to Damascus, restoring diplomatic ties, signals potential trade deals for phosphate and wheat, and future security partnerships, leveraging Ukraine's defense-tech prowess to modernize Syria's army and infrastructure. Turkey, led by President Erdogan, is facilitating this "odd throuple," benefiting from Russia's diminishing influence in the Middle East and Caucasus, and aiming to build a new European security architecture that includes Ukraine and Turkey.

As Russia looks to slash budgets, a village fights to survive

The Russian village of Nikolsk is fiercely resisting government plans to cut its school's upper forms, a move openly attributed by officials to budget strains from the war in Ukraine. Despite Nikolsk's relative prosperity and growth, Moscow's abolition of local self-governance means villagers' opinions are dismissed. Residents, drawing on a history of dissent and self-reliance, are

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organizing protests and legal challenges to preserve their community, which has thrived through local enterprise and does not want to suffer for the state's military priorities.

How Europe regulated itself into American vassalage

Charlemagne argues that Europe's economic dependency on American firms in technology, finance, and energy is largely self-imposed, stemming from decades of over-regulation. A tangle of national and EU rules, while aiming for laudable goals like green targets and privacy protection, stifled European businesses, preventing them from achieving the scale needed to compete with agile US giants. This regulatory burden created barriers to entry that inadvertently protected American firms, leading to a quiet "economic vassalage" that leaves Europe exposed, especially in an era of weaponized economic entanglements by figures like Donald Trump.

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BRITAIN

Britain rethinks its 'special relationship' with America

The "special relationship" between Britain and America is severely strained, reminiscent of the 1956 Suez crisis, exacerbated by the Iran war and President Donald Trump's impatience with European allies. King Charles III's upcoming visit aims to smooth relations amidst fallout from the Jeffrey Epstein scandal and a deep rift between Trump and Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer. British public approval of America has plummeted, and the UK's armed forces are seen as diminished and dependent on US might, leading to calls for Britain to rebalance its foreign policy closer to Europe.

The international problem of weasel words

America and Britain, "two nations divided by a common language," frequently miscommunicate due to differing

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interpretations of "weasel words" or "estimative probability," such as "highly likely." Research shows that listeners assign widely varying probabilities to such phrases, with Americans tending to be more optimistic. The article notes that intelligence organizations like NATO and the British government have calibrated these terms with numerical values to prevent misunderstanding, suggesting that direct, precise language is crucial, especially in high-stakes diplomatic interactions.

British nukes are utterly reliant on America

Britain's nuclear deterrent is profoundly dependent on America for almost every aspect, from warhead design and non-fissile components to missile storage and testing, under long-standing agreements like the Mutual Defence Agreement of 1958. While British Trident D5 missiles can be fired independently, a crash program to develop a fully home-grown nuclear capability without US cooperation would be extraordinarily expensive, take

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decades, and face significant technical challenges, particularly in designing and validating new warheads and producing specialized components.

A wave of antisemitic attacks in Britain reveals a new threat

A recent wave of antisemitic attacks in London, including arson and firebombings against Jewish institutions, reveals an evolving threat that may involve hostile states like Iran recruiting local criminals for "vandalism for hire." These operations, often crude and carried out by inexperienced individuals, aim to create fear and confusion at low cost to the orchestrators, and are facilitated through social media. This shift in tactics from direct agents to outsourced criminal activity presents a dismal development that poses a persistent danger beyond the current Iran conflict.

Britain's reliance on Ukrainian eggs is ruffling feathers

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Britain's reliance on Ukrainian egg imports has surged, doubling since 2021 to meet domestic demand amidst bird flu culls and rising production costs. This tariff-free trade, an act of solidarity after Russia's invasion, has angered British farmers who claim they are being undercut by cheaper Ukrainian eggs, many of which come from battery cages banned in Britain. Concerns are rising about consumer awareness of egg origins and the fairness of competition, while Ukraine benefits from these agricultural exports to aid its war effort.

Waterstones shows there is still life in the British high street

Waterstones, the British bookshop chain, is thriving amidst the decline of the high street by prioritizing traditional retailing principles. Under CEO James Daunt, the company closed underperforming stores, invested in remaining branches, empowered staff with local autonomy over stock and layout, and fostered a welcoming browsing environment with amenities like

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cafés. This curated, customer-centric approach, combined with a growing online presence, has allowed Waterstones to flourish, becoming a "pit stop" for footfall and a model for other retailers.

Sir Keir Starmer cannot govern. He has only himself to blame

Despite commanding a large parliamentary majority, Britain's Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer's government is perceived as "ungoverned" and ineffective, a situation Bagehot argues is largely self-inflicted. Blunders like the Peter Mandelson ambassadorial scandal, cack-handed welfare reforms, and a refusal to implement bolder fiscal policies have squandered his political capital and demoralized his party. Starmer's tendency to blame the civil service or "events" for his woes, rather than his own leadership, has left him in office but not in power, triggering contempt rather than faith among his colleagues.

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INTERNATIONAL

Anduril, Palantir and SpaceX are changing how America wages war

A new clique of "neo-primes"—Palantir, SpaceX, and Anduril—are rapidly reshaping America's defence industry, offering cheaper, smarter, and faster solutions for modern warfare, especially against drones. These tech upstarts, favored by the Trump administration and fueled by venture capital, are challenging traditional defence giants with fixed-price contracts, rapid innovation, and AI-infused command-and-control systems. While promising to accelerate military procurement and capabilities, concerns remain about their scalability, potential market dominance, the ethical implications of autonomous weapons, and the cozy relations between the Trump family and these firms.

There is no better spur to military

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innovation than war

Ukraine's defence industry is experiencing rapid innovation and exponential growth in unmanned systems, with companies like Ratel Robotics developing UGVs and drones that are transforming the battlefield. This "industrial Darwinism," contrasting with Russia's state-run programs, allows new models to reach the front in months, enabling Ukraine to inflict significant casualties and force changes in Russian tactics. Despite challenges in procurement and corruption, Ukraine's dynamic and competitive market has significantly boosted its drone production and extended its strike capabilities deep into Russia.

Europe's defence startups face even bigger hurdles than America's

European defence-tech startups, despite advancing in unmanned systems, struggle to scale production due to a fragmented market of many national buyers and cautious

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customers. Unlike American firms benefiting from large Pentagon contracts, European companies face diverse procurement rules and a persistent debate about balancing conventional arms with cheaper, software-heavy weapons. While some governments, notably Germany, are increasing orders and EU schemes favor European suppliers, these firms remain "minnows" compared to their American counterparts, with ongoing challenges in rapid production and procurement reform.

A dangerous blind spot in Donald Trump's Iran war strategy

Donald Trump's Iran war strategy reflects a recurring American "dangerous blind spot": the tendency to underestimate foreigners' beliefs and values, a mistake evident in past conflicts like Kosovo. The article argues that Trump's over-reliance on threats, impetuosity, and lack of cultural curiosity mirror previous administrations' failures to understand adversaries, leading to prolonged and ineffective military engagements. This fundamental

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flaw, even when shedding "excessive idealism," results in strategies that aim for cultural change without accounting for the profound, often unyielding, nature of national identity and worldview, thereby repeating costly mistakes.

1843

The Republican congressman taking on Trump

Thomas Massie, a Republican congressman from Kentucky, has launched a solitary rebellion against Donald Trump, repeatedly defying the president's policies and enduring his public attacks. Massie, a libertarian-leaning conservative and off-grid farmer, voted against Trump's spending plans, opposed military action in Iran, and successfully championed legislation to release the Jeffrey Epstein files, earning him national

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renown and powerful supporters. The article details Massie's background as an MIT-trained engineer and his "outside game" political strategy, driven by a deep mistrust of federal power and a commitment to self-reliance, which he believes inoculates him from political corruption, even as he faces a tough primary challenge backed by Trump.

BUSINESS

Apple's new boss needs to restore its magic for the AI era

John Ternus, Apple's newly appointed CEO, faces the critical challenge of revitalizing the company's innovation in the AI era, following Tim Cook's remarkable but operationally focused tenure. While Cook oversaw immense growth through continuous iPhone improvements, Apple has lagged in developing

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foundational AI services. Terner, the hardware chief, is expected to either make existing products ubiquitous as AI interfaces or develop new "form factors" like smartglasses, leveraging Apple's custom silicon to maintain its hardware advantage, while also navigating complex supply chain shifts away from China.

Jeff Bezos is raising his game in space

Jeff Bezos's rocket firm, Blue Origin, achieved a significant milestone by successfully landing a reusable New Glenn rocket booster, but then faltered by placing its satellite payload into the wrong orbit, leading to its destruction and a grounding. This setback adds to Blue Origin's ambitious agenda, which includes developing a space tug, a space station, and a lunar lander, alongside Amazon's satellite-internet service, Leo. Despite heavy investment from Bezos, Amazon's Leo project remains significantly behind SpaceX's Starlink, and the recent grounding could further delay its deployment.

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Why your AI assistant is suddenly selling to you

AI chatbots are increasingly integrating advertisements, transforming into "adbots" as companies like OpenAI and Google seek to monetize their expensive AI models. This new form of digital advertising allows brands to sponsor chat replies, with OpenAI reportedly aiming for significant ad revenue by 2030. While Google's AI Mode shows immediate ads like a search engine, ChatGPT bides its time, with nearly a third of its ads appearing after multiple turns in a conversation, suggesting a new, more nuanced approach to marketing in interactive AI.

From Allbirds to Glossier, millennial brands have lost their mojo

Once-buzzy millennial brands like Allbirds, Glossier, and Warby Parker, which thrived on direct-to-consumer online sales and social media marketing, are now struggling amidst rising interest rates, increased

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customer acquisition costs, and stiffer competition. Allbirds even announced a pivot to AI computing infrastructure, highlighting the existential crises many face. Their initial success was fueled by cheap capital and social media, but these advantages have waned, forcing many to build physical retail presences and adapt to a tougher market, while a new generation of celebrity-led upstarts gains traction.

Donald Trump is giving psychedelic medicines a welcome boost

Donald Trump's executive order to accelerate the approval of psychedelic drugs for mental illness represents a significant boost for the field, promising new funding for research and expedited FDA reviews. However, critics warn that Trump's approach risks politicizing drug development by prioritizing relationships over scientific merit, potentially undermining the integrity of the approval process and public trust. While companies like Compass Pathways

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and Definium are close to filing applications for drugs like psilocybin and LSD, concerns exist about the rigorous evaluation of safety and efficacy, particularly given past patient deaths linked to some psychedelics.

The curious rise of Chinese whisky

Chinese whisky is experiencing a curious boom, with over 50 new distilleries and record imports, defying a general decline in other alcohol sales like baijiu, beer, and wine. This surge is driven by whisky's growing status as a luxury product among affluent Chinese consumers and surprisingly successful overseas marketing efforts. Major international spirits-makers like Diageo and Pernod Ricard are investing heavily, and new national standards for single malt are being introduced, solidifying whisky's position as a thriving tipple in an otherwise dispirited market.

America's descent into state capitalism is exaggerated

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Schumpeter argues that claims of America's descent into state capitalism under Donald Trump are exaggerated, despite the president's rhetoric and interventions in markets. The administration's attempts to control business, from capping credit-card rates to influencing tech firms, have often been ineffective, with markets largely shrugging off his bluster. While the federal bureaucracy is investing in strategic industries like rare earths and chips, the scale of this intervention pales in comparison to other nations, and Trump's approach is characterized more by bullying and transactional deals than by comprehensive central planning, showcasing a dynamic, if loud, form of capitalism.

FINANCE & ECONOMICS

**Xi Jinping wants a powerful currency.
America's war has helped**

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Xi Jinping's ambition for a powerful yuan is gaining traction, significantly aided by America's ongoing war with Iran, which has driven more countries to use China's payment infrastructure. Transactions on China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS) surged, likely due to Iran's increased use of yuan for oil and toll payments through the Strait of Hormuz, alongside capital flows from the Gulf. Furthermore, China's low interest rates make yuan-denominated "Panda" and "dim sum" bonds attractive to foreign companies and governments, providing a "comfortable" alternative to the dollar for those seeking to diversify their financial platforms.

Chinamaxxing is starting to catch on, in China

The internet meme "Chinamaxxing," originating in Western social media where Gen-Zers adopt Chinese habits and showcase futuristic skylines, is now boosting foreign tourism and demand for Chinese goods, creating a "new wave of global cultural engagement." This

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imported enthusiasm, combined with new visa-free entry programs, has led to record numbers of foreign visitors and increased spending in China, with local officials and businesses noting a direct positive impact on their economies, although its long-term sustainability remains uncertain.

American corporate profits keep shrugging off global tumult

American corporate profits remain remarkably strong, defying global tumult from the Iran war and trade conflicts, with S&P 500 earnings estimated to have risen 19% in the first quarter and forecasts predicting a 24% increase over the next 12 months. This bullishness is primarily driven by the artificial intelligence boom, with Nvidia and other chipmakers making significant contributions to overall earnings growth, alongside robust performance in finance, materials, and pharmaceuticals. The resilience stems from American companies' strong starting position, innovation, pricing

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power, and consumers' continued willingness to spend, despite external geopolitical risks and potential domestic policy meddling.

Global energy markets are on the verge of a disaster

Global energy markets are teetering on the brink of disaster 50 days into the Iran war, with 550m barrels of Gulf crude and significant LNG supplies lost, and all initial seaborne oil buffers now exhausted. Asian countries, particularly reliant on Gulf exports, are facing dwindling inventories and refineries slashing throughput, while European countries, subsidizing consumption, are pushing their refiners into the red as crude prices soar. Without an immediate reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, the world faces compounding shortages, extreme price hikes, and a potential 10% fall in oil demand, mirroring the economic shock of the 2020 covid lockdowns.

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Renewables are shining. The Iran war amplifies their appeal

The Iran war is significantly amplifying the appeal of clean energy, particularly solar power, which is increasingly undercutting fossil fuels. New reports from the International Energy Agency and Ember highlight that solar photovoltaics met over 25% of the world's new energy demand in 2025, and renewables collectively generated more electricity than coal for the first time in over a century. The tumbling costs and enhanced energy security offered by renewables, as they operate independently of geopolitical turmoil, make them an increasingly compelling solution for energy-starved governments worldwide.

The stablecoin market has got too stable

The once-rapid growth of the stablecoin market has stalled, with total assets barely budging after a period of significant expansion, despite previous bullish forecasts

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from regulators and financial institutions. This "excessive stability" is attributed to ongoing regulatory uncertainty, including new proposals for stricter anti-money-laundering rules that impose significant costs on issuers, and a lack of significant real-world demand. Stablecoins' primary use remains crypto trading rather than payments, diminishing their perceived threat to traditional banking and easing earlier concerns from the American Bankers Association.

Has the World Bank performed a U-turn on industrial policy?

The World Bank's new report, "Industrial Policy for Development," guiding governments on economic intervention, has been perceived by some as a "surrender" of the long-standing Washington Consensus advocating free markets. While the report cautiously approaches "market incentives" like subsidies and tariffs, it is less averse to "public inputs" such as infrastructure spending and training initiatives, aligning with some

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historical advice. Ultimately, the report's main innovation is acknowledging the widespread reality of governments already committed to industrial policies, offering minimally distortive advice rather than a full endorsement of statist approaches, and implicitly warning against the risks of past failures.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Scientists are still learning from the Chernobyl nuclear disaster

Forty years after the Chernobyl nuclear disaster, scientists continue to extract valuable lessons from it, using the site as a unique laboratory to study the long-term biological, ecological, and sociological impacts of nuclear accidents. Researchers track the movement of radionuclides through water and soil, developing agricultural countermeasures like chemical

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feeds and soil inoculation, while also discovering extremophile bacteria breaking down radioactive materials within the ruined reactor. Despite ongoing challenges, including recent damage to the New Safe Confinement, the findings are crucial for managing future nuclear incidents and informing radiation risk perceptions.

How to stop colour-blind grouse flying into ski lifts

New research has solved the decades-long problem of black grouse colliding with ski-lift cables in the Alps: the birds are color-blind to red, the dominant color of most warning markers. By studying captive-bred grouse vision and eye receptor proteins, scientists discovered that the birds can see contrast and other colors like yellow and purple, but not red. The solution involves using larger, strongly contrasting color combinations like purple and yellow or black and white for markers, placed more frequently, to effectively deter the grouse and reduce

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collisions.

Crypto-miners are quietly colonising computers

"Crypto-jacking," the illicit practice of remotely hijacking computers to mine cryptocurrency, is booming, with instances rising by 20% in 2025 as miners seek to cut costs by offloading energy consumption onto unsuspecting victims. Web-crawling bots exploit weak security settings and stolen login credentials to deploy stealthy, fileless crypto-mining software onto corporate servers and personal devices, generating significant financial losses for victims. Despite efforts from security firms and tech giants like Google, the arms race continues, fueled by the high value of cryptocurrencies like Monero and the difficulty of detecting evolving attack methods.

Is bone broth good for you?

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Scientific evidence for the purported health benefits of bone broth, a popular wellness drink, remains sparse and inconclusive. While it contains protein that can promote satiety and compounds like glucosamine that might lessen joint pain, studies have not consistently proven its efficacy for weight loss, improved skin/bone density, or significant gut healing due to typically low concentrations of beneficial nutrients. Although wholesome and comforting, its claimed "magic" lacks strong scientific backing, suggesting its main impact is on the wallet rather than health.

CULTURE

The rhetoric of war has changed. Not for the better

The rhetoric of war in the West has dramatically shifted from the eloquent, morally grounded speeches of

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historical leaders like Churchill and Roosevelt to the belligerent, pop-culture-infused language exemplified by Donald Trump and Pete Hegseth during the Iran war. This loss of literary allusion and elevation of tone, replaced by jarring Hollywood clips and misquoted scripture, is lamented as a significant cultural decline. The article argues that while oratory can be deceptive, historical war rhetoric served to imbue conflicts with purpose and a vision of peace, a quality now absent, leaving a sense of loss for a more dignified public discourse.

In the AI propaganda war, Iran is winning

In a surprising turn, Iran's theocratic regime is effectively winning the AI propaganda war against the US, releasing witty, English-language, AI-generated videos that quickly go viral and ridicule Donald Trump and his administration. These cheaply and rapidly produced videos leverage Western cultural tropes and global criticisms of Trump, effectively tapping into internet

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subcultures and memes, despite the regime's repressive nature. While often containing blatant propaganda and antisemitic images, their cultural fluency and ability to respond quickly to current events have made them highly persuasive and engaging to a global audience, outmaneuvering America's own efforts.

In a new biopic, Michael Jackson is an eccentric saint. Yuck

The new biopic "Michael" presents a "triumphant version" of Michael Jackson's life, portraying him as an eccentric saint who sublimated pain into joy, while controversially glossing over the serious allegations of child abuse against him. The film, which closes before the alleged abuses at Neverland Ranch, focuses on his musical genius and philanthropic aspirations, aiming to beatify him and recruit new fans. The author criticizes this "nauseous feeling of omission," arguing that while Jackson's songs are "uncancellable" and his rightful memorial, the film's narrative reflects a modern tendency

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to rewrite history and prioritize fame over accountability and truth.

Judy Blume's radical honesty changed literature for ever

Mark Oppenheimer's new biography, "Judy Blume: A Life," chronicles the trailblazing career of Judy Blume, whose "frank, candid, earthy" novels revolutionized young adult literature by openly addressing puberty, sex, and self-discovery. Despite selling over 80 million copies and becoming an "agony aunt" for her fans, her radical honesty frequently sparked contention and censorship attempts from adults who feared her books would lead their children astray. The biography highlights her profound impact on literature, arguing that stories helping adolescents navigate confusing times should be celebrated, not censored, even as the author admits struggling to fully capture Blume's personal depth.

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Runaway success: marathon organisers are seeing record demand

Marathon running is experiencing runaway success globally, with organizers seeing record demand and participation, particularly among Gen-Z runners who have embraced the sport post-pandemic. Prestigious races like the London and New York City Marathons receive unprecedented numbers of applicants, prompting organizers to expand events and consider multi-day formats. This "marathon mania" is fueled by individuals pushing themselves to go farther and faster, demonstrating a sustained fitness habit and a strong desire for the challenge and prestige of completing major races.

Ibram X. Kendi's illiberal views on race are out of favour. Good

Ibram X. Kendi's "rigid and hortatory" views on race, which gained prominence in recent years, are now falling

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out of favor, as evidenced by his center's staff cuts and the lukewarm reception for his new book. The author criticizes Kendi's Manichean worldview, which asserts everyone is either "racist" or "antiracist," and his proposals for state intervention and "present discrimination" as illiberal and counterproductive. The article suggests that Kendi's renown was an "artefact of a febrile time" and that his approach is unsuited for the complexities of liberal democracy, where compromise and incremental change are essential.

ECONOMIC & FINANCIAL INDICATORS

Economic data, commodities and markets

No significant coverage this issue.

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OBITUARY

Mark Mobius dared to go where few others did

Mark Mobius, a pioneering emerging-markets fund manager known as "Indiana Jones on Wall Street," died at 89. He revolutionized investment by daring to venture into politically unstable or debt-ridden "bad" countries, believing chaos presented buying opportunities. Mobius grew Franklin Templeton's emerging-markets fund from \$100m to \$40bn by 2018, meticulously researching companies and visiting factories worldwide. His optimistic, calculated-risk approach brought emerging markets into mainstream asset classes and promoted market economies globally, though he never married, humorously citing the unpredictable risks.